



jEdit is released under the GNU GPL version 2.0. It is a cross-platform text editor written in Java, keeping in mind all kinds of programmers. It runs on any platform with Java support. Its development was started by the founding author Slava Pestov in 1998, who then left the project in 2006, handing it over to the Free Software Community.

Features and plug-ins

The key features that distinguish *jEdit* from other text editors are:

- Being a programmer's editor, *jEdit* supports syntax highlighting for more than 200 languages.
- It has a built-in macro language.
- It has auto-indent, along with capacious code-folding capabilities.
- It supports a large number of character encodings, including UTF-8 and Unicode.
- It's highly configurable and customisable.
- You can even add support for additional formats manually, using XML files.
- You can script it and record macros too.

jEdit has over 200 plug-ins available for several different application areas. The 'Plugin Manager' helps you download and install these (along with updates) from within the editor itself, so you don't have to hunt the Internet for plug-ins and manually install them. Plug-in windows can be shown either as separate, top-level frames, or as 'docked windows' in the editor window. These powerful plug-ins can turn *jEdit* into a very advanced XML/HTML editor, or even a full-fledged IDE with a compiler, debugger, the code-completion feature and many other tools.

Installation is simple; being Java-based, ensure you have a compatible Java Virtual Machine (Java 2 version 1.6 or later is required to run *jEdit* 4.4 and later) on your system. Download the stable or development versions of *jEdit* from <http://www.jedit.org/index.php?page=download>, and for Linux choose a Java-based installer (*jar*). I would recommend the

development version, as you find a lot more enhancements in it than on the stable version, and more recent versions of plug-ins.

On the first launch, you will find a *help* window, which is really valuable. You will also get a *Tip of the Day* each time you run *jEdit*—yet another way to learn useful stuff.

Working with jEdit

To start with, let's try a simple HTML page. Before that, just install a plug-in that detects and fixes HTML errors for you. Go to *Plugins>Plugin Manager>Install* (see Figure 1) and select *JTidyPlugin* and install it. Next, click *File>New in mode* and select *html*. Type in the following code:

```
<html>
<head>
<title>LFY
</head>
<body>
We love Linux for You!!!
</body>
</html>
```

Now, use the installed plug-in. Click on *Plugins>JTidy>Tidy current Buffer*. This tool will open a new file containing fixed code, as shown in Figure 2. Save the file and view it in your browser. Wasn't that easy? Similarly, you can download other plug-ins as per your need—you won't need any other editing tool!

Pros and cons

As noted, *jEdit* is eminently configurable to individual preferences—it can be 'taught' to do things your way. Keyboard short-cuts, which are important for power users, are of course customisable.

Strangely, this advantage is also its major disadvantage. Configuring *jEdit* to your needs is a time-consuming process,